

Post-Mortem: May Billing Outage

Impact

On May 14, invoice processing halted for 3 hours 40 minutes after a schema migration locked the invoices table. 2,300 invoices were delayed; no data was lost. SEV1 declared at 09:12 UTC, resolved 12:52 UTC.

Timeline

09:02 migration deployed. 09:08 Prometheus alerts fired on invoice queue depth. 09:12 oncall paged via PagerDuty and declared SEV1. 09:30 rollback attempted but blocked by the long-running lock. 11:45 lock terminated after replica promotion. 12:52 queue drained, status page green.

Root cause

The migration added a NOT NULL column with a default, rewriting the table under an exclusive lock — a pattern the schema migrations guide forbids. The pre-deploy check that flags table rewrites was disabled by a stale feature flag.

Action items

Re-enable the migration linter and remove the bypass flag (done). Add lock-time budget alerts to Grafana dashboards. Rehearse replica promotion in the incident runbook quarterly. Feature flag cleanup log now tracks stale flags monthly.